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Conservation of ethnomedicila plants through traditional health care system and religious practices by "Oraons" of Ranchi district, Jharkhand, India

Pushpa Salo Linda[a], Dara Singh gupta[b] & Agatha S. Khalkho[c]

Assistant Professor, Deptt. Of Botany, Jamshedpur worker's College, Jamshedpur.

Assistant Professor, Deptt. Of Botany, Jamshedpur Co-operative College, Jamshedpur.

Associate Professor, Deptt. Of Botany, Marwari College, Ranchi

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Abstract : Ranchi district is rich in forest wealth and Ethnic communities especially "Oraon" Tribe. Each ethnic community maintains a Traditional Wealth care System on local floras. Despite the modern civilization, the tribal still dependent on the ancient method of treatment and herbs of ethnic value which they find easily available and think most effective and convenient. There is many ethno-botanical, as well as ethno-medicinal plants, which are used specific by "Oraon" Tribe for the ailment of different types of diseases. Few of the plants used widely are ***Boerhaavia diffusa-Punarnava, Adhatoda vasia-vasak, Aegle marmelos-Bael, Ricinus communis-Arandi Vitex negund-Sindwar, Madhuka langi folia-Mahua, Pangamia pinnata-Karanj, Scheichera oleose-Kusum, Terminalia arjuna, t.Bellerica-Behera, T. chebula-Harra, Bombax ceiba-Shimal, Syzgium cumin-Jamun, Bambusa anrudinacea-Bamboo, Mangifera indica-Aam etc.*** Some plants are used in Social Forestry Programs as agro-forestry and road side plantation. For the conservation of traditional knowledge & their health benefits, they try to conserve, protect the ethno-medicinal plants, around them. Their religious practices also help in conservation of biodiversity.

Keywords : Ethno-medicinal plants, Religious practices, Agro-forestry, Socio-religious

INTRODUCTION

As we all know Jharkhand is a plateau region covered with forests. Forests are godsend for Tribal way of living. Their life starts from forest and ends in the forest. Their each and every work is related with nature. Even their festivals, rituals are also related with nature. However, it is believed that using one plant, as a part of ritual or religious practice is not only good for individual's health but, also helps in the preservation & maintenance of biodiversity.

Ranchi District is rich in forest wealth and Ethnic Communities especially "Oraon". They have Traditional Healthcare System based on local floras. They use plants parts like root, stems, leaves, flowers, tree barks, seeds, fruits as remedy for many diseases under their Traditional Healthcare arrangement, and they are depend up on Jari-Butti's. So, they protect the plants with medicinal value and also they pass their medicinal knowledge to their children, grand children so there knowledge is not lost. Their traditional beliefs and uses of plants for traditional and religious customs and practices enhance the conservation of plant diversity & in the true sense; ***"Oraons are the custodians of our natural diversity."***

*Corresponding author :

Phone :

E-mail :

The Oraons

The Orans are the second largest tribe in the state. The "Oraons" are inhabitants of Ranchi, Gumla, Lohardage, Latehar, Palamu, Garhwa, Hazaribagh, dhanbad, Santhal Parganaand Singhbhum. According to the traditions, Konkan is said to be original home of the Oraons. Owing to overpopulation and external pressure, they migrated from the west coast of India to north India. After some time, they settled down as agriculturists and landowners in the Shahabad district of Bihar. Driven by the successive hordes of new races, they look shelter on the Rohtas plateau. They fortified the place but could not

make it impregnable; probably they were driven out by the Cheros. While moving out from Rohtas, the Oraons split up into two branches. One branch proceeds down the Ganges and settled in the Rajmahal hills. Another branch proceeded south eastwards and settled down in Palamu and northwest of Ranchi district, then occupied by the Mundas.

The Oraons with better equipment and better knowledge of agriculture multiplied rapidly and became predominant in the northwestern and central part of the Chhotanagpur Plateau.

Religion

The Oraon religion practice is a mixture of Animism, Bongaism, Spiritism, Naturalism etc. Sing Bonga or Dharmesh is the Chief deity of the Oraon. The ancestral Gods reside in ***"Sasan".*** Other Gods reside in ***"Sarana grove".*** Family deity resides in the house. The Pahan is the religious head; He conducts the ceremonial rituals at the time of sacramental sacrifices and ceremonies. Their festivals are Sarhul, Karma, Sohrai etc. the peculiarities of these festivals is they all revolve around the worship of particular plant of a particular season. Example; Sarhul is celebrated in the month of April, which is the month airborne diseases. Branch of Sal ***(sakhua)*** is kept in the homes for air purification as prevention of chickenpox.

MATERIALS AND METHOD

In different seasons survey was done in different villages of Ranchi District. And during our survey, elderly people, Paha, Vaidhya, in villages were interviewed. The plant samples were collected and herbanium were prepared and identified.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

"Oraon" Tribe of Ranchi district uses different parts of various plants in their ancient method of treatment to cure different ailments. It not only promotes good health but also helps in maintaining a balanced ecological environment. Plants, that are used in traditional health care are described in Table-I. The ancestors had left various religious beliefs for the tribe towards nature and modulated with religion and made it a way of life. Hence, it was a very constructive approach towards the conservation of plant biodiversity from their time to present day. There are many sacred graves found among the Oraons villaged are "Sarna", "Sasan" etc. "Sarna" is a place, where religious practices are done by Pahan. ***Sarna*** is a ***Kurukh*** word which means collection of plants or groups of pants. In sarna many plants are protected for religious function. In "Sasan", many pants are planted and protected. ***(In modern world same process is known as gene banking; preserving of seeds for their future generations & protection of plants. This was known by the oraon tribes thousands of years ago and when this was linked with religion it became mandatory for the tribesmen to preserve seeds and passing of knowledge to their siblings.)***

Thus, they associate plants with religious practices and help in the conservation of pant biodiversity. Some of the plants that are being conserved in this way are described in Table-I.

Table-1 : List of plant species and therir medicinal and religious uses

Ser No.	Plants Name	Family	Local Name	Medical Uses For	Religious Uses
1.	Anona squamosa	Annoraceae	Sharifa	Anemic Patient	
2.	Adhatoda vasica	Solanaceae	Vakas	Given in Asthma	
3.	Aegle marmelos	Rutaceae	Beal	Ripe fruit is aromatic, astringent cooling and laxative, The unripe or half ripe fruit is given in dysentery.	
4.	Azadiracta indica	Meliaceae	Neem	Dried leaves are used for blood purification. The fresh juices of leaves are used in Skin diseases.	
5.	Amaranthus spinoses	Amaranthaceae	Chawlai Sag	Leaves are used for Hemoglobin.	
6.	Asparagus raemosus	Liliaceas	Satavani	Piles	
7.	Boerhavia diffusa	Nyctaginaceae	Punarnawa	Eaten by Anemic Patient.	
8.	Banhinia variegate	Caesal piniaceae	Kachnar	Tender leaves are eaten by Anemic Patient.	
9.	Celastrus paniculata	Celartraceae	Kujuri	Taken by Anemic Patient.	
10.	Cajanus cajan	Papilionaceae	Arhar	The juices of leaves are used with sugar candy for jaundice.	

Ser No.	Plants Name	Family	Local Name	Medical Uses For	Religious Uses
11.	Centela asiatica	Umbelliferae	Brahmi	Leaves are used in Jaundice.	
12.	Cassia tora	Caesalpiniaceae	Chakunda	Tender leaves are used as vegetable, which is beneficial for anemic and diabetic patient.	
13.	Carica papaya	Caricaceae	Papita	After child birth, boiled papaya is given to mother.	
14.	Curuma langa	Ziziberaceae	Haldi	Zow zinger used for removing clotted blood.	
15.	Diospyros malabarica	Ebenaceae	Tendu	Dried fruits are used in dysentery.	
16.	Emblica officinalis	Euphorbiaceae	Amla	It is richest source of vitamin-C. It is given in dysentery also.	
17.	Enhydra flactuance	Asteraceae	Muchri Sag	Leaves are eaten for Hemoglobin.	
18.	Ficus infictoria	Moraceae	Phutkal	Tender leaves are boiled and dried and then given in dysentery.	
19.	Ficus glomerulata	Moraceae	Gular	Fruits are used in dysentery.	
20.	Hibiscus rosa sinensis	Malvaceae	Urhul Phul	Buds are eaten by Anemic Patient.	
21.	Mangifera indica	Anacardiaceae	Aam	Juice of roasted, unripe fruits is given to patient of Loo (Hot wind stroke).	
22.	Moringa oleifera	Moringaceae	Sahjan, Munga	Leaves are eaten in Blood Pressure.	
23.	Mimosa pudica	Mimosaceae	Chui-Mui (Lajwanti)	Leaves fruits or root is given with Sugar Candy for piles.	
24.	Madhuka longifolia	Sapotaceae	Mahuwa	Oil is used in removing pain of stomach.	
25.	Ocimum sanctium	Lamiaceae	Tulsi	Leaves are used in Cough & Cold.	
26.	Pangamia pinnota	Papilionraceae	Karanja	Seeds oil is used in the treatment of skin diseases.	
27.	Punica granatum	Punicaceae	Anar	Used in Piles.	
28.	Ricinus communis	Euphorbiaceae	Arandi	Tender shoots, branches are used in toothache.	
29.	Salmalia Malabaricum	Bombacaeae	Semul	After boiling of bark given to Anemic Patient.	
30.	Syzygium Cumini	Myrtaceae	Jamun	Fruit is used by Anemic Patient.	
31.	Shorea robusta	Dipterocarpaceae	Sal	The dried seeds are after boiling converted into powder and given dysentery patient.	
32.	Swertia chirayta	Gnetianaeae	Chiraita	Tonic	
33.	Tamarindus incica	Caesalpiniaceae	Imli	The fruits are edible and are used as carminative and laxative. Powder of tender dried leaves is used in dysentery.	
34.	Terminelia bellirica	Cambertaceae	Bahera	The ripe dried fruit is astringent, bitter tonic and laxative. It is given in piles, diarrhea, headache etc.	
35.	Terminelia chebula	Combertaceae	Harara	The fruits are of medicinal value. The fruit pulp is given in Diarrhea, Dysentery, vomiting etc.	
36.	Vitex negundo	Verbinaceae	Sindwar	Leaves are used.	
37.	Vinca rosea	Apocynaceae	Sadabahar	Leaves are used in blood pressure,	

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